

Such are the open beaches of the western and southern shores. The fishing areas to the north and east are different. There are thus no shore seines operating, and although gill nets and scoops are used in and near reeds, the most widespread gear in these areas is the trap. In the dry season one must walk about two miles across the grassy plain, across mud flats, and finally onto the hardened mud of the reed bed to reach the shallow boat channels leading out into the lake. (In the rainy season much of the plain is under water.) The fishermen live in the reed beds or on floating islands and come to the selling points every one, two, or even four weeks. They sometimes keep the fish caught in garaga, baskets suspended in the water where the fish are kept alive and fed, or else they dry or smoke them ready for sale. The reed beds of the north, especially, support a large fishing population. The fishermen live in small temporary structures, varying from small huts to mere tents of bent-over reeds. These may be on dryer patches of reed beds closer to shore or on the zimbowera, which are made by piling up reeds and grass above the level of the water. Information so far received suggests that these zimbowera are of fairly recent origin, perhaps even within the last decade or so, and would

A typical scene on the open beaches of Lake Chilwa would be the following: One or more khoka teams operate their nets; canoes are paddled out into the lake where the men shoot the net. Then begins the long, slow, rhythmic pull-in of two tow ropes of the net by the team of labourers. The whole operation from shooting to the next takes about one and a half hours for the average-sized khoka. The catch is collected from the bag of the net in buckets and tipped out onto mats; the fish are sorted out and put to dry or be smoked ready for sale. Then there are the other fishermen, two pulling a chirimira, others with scoops or nets (although many of these fish at night); gill nets are being reset or checked along the edges of the reed beds or farther out in open water. There is also generally a spot where the boat channels emerge from the reed beds, where fishermen from the reeds come to sell their fish to traders. All over the ground are mats of matemba drying in the sun, spread out for potential buyers (both local individuals and traders process the fish themselves). On some beaches are smoke houses long, low-eaved huts--with a series of open, smoky wood fires underneath racks from the fish are spread out to be cured. The traders rent smoking racks from the owners of the house for about 2/- for ever 11 worth of fish and also pay for the wood. These smoke houses are popular meeting places for men, somewhat as water points are for women. Some distance back from the beach are the temporary, though often well-built and decorated, houses of the fishermen and in some places more permanent structures, too. There are the canteens, tea rooms, bars, and small stores selling a range of groceries and other common goods, all in the smallest weight packages, well as blankets and cotton materials.

Then there is the "head" (the English word is used), who is a deputy to the owner of the bwana. He is occasionally a relative, but the most important criterion for him to be someone the owner can trust. Next in line is the "capitao," the labourer. Then comes the team of labourers and the cook, who does not fish. Monthly pay for the labourers is usually 12/10 but may be only 11 for any young boys on the team. The capitao may earn as much as 10/- more than the other labourers and the head may earn as much as 14 a month. Labourers will normally work for season though some for only a few months at a time. The capitao may remain for and the head might work for three to five years for one bwana. More research is needed on the structure and changes in these companies (see Hill 1970).